is pressed into service to provide background material about Indian thinking on the subject matter of the forthcoming negotiation. Diplomatic channels are used to take soundings and to gauge expectations in advance of the negotiations. The objective of Chinese probing is to identify the points of possible convergence and divergence ahead of the negotiations, or as Alfred D. Wilhelm puts it, the idea is to make heads begin to pop up and to identify the targets in order to prepare tentative solutions. [1] Personal information on the key negotiators on the opposite side, especially their connections with China, is deemed valuable. Internal consultations are then held to evolve a clear strategy and tactics. This is something that the Indian side could learn lessons from.

China will always try to set the agenda for negotiations. Few other cultures endow such significance to this stage of the negotiation, presuming that they can negotiate from ambiguity to their own advantage later in the negotiations, but in fact they will then be reminded by the Chinese of the agreed terms and brought back to the track preferred by the Chinese. [2] China tries through such means to determine the direction of talks, and to avoid discussing subjects that may paint China into a corner or compel the Chinese negotiator to disclose their position prematurely. If China does not wish to discuss a matter, the standard ploy is to claim that an issue is not 'ripe for settlement'. It is generally China that determines if this is the case with respect to any issue. A Chinese draft agenda will thus contain clues on the likely direction of talks, and also what the Chinese are hoping to achieve and to avoid. The tendency of the opposite party is to acquiesce to the Chinese agenda out of a sense of politeness or in order to keep the atmosphere of talks positive, and that is precisely what the Chinese desire. It is, therefore, important for the other party to raise its own issues of interest in the working level negotiations even if these are